

OPAUDIT 018 — The exe that launched was not the one we built

Audit ID	2026-09-15-018
Report date	2026-09-15
First observed	2026-09-15 evening. Sean launched SMACK YOUR BATCH UP from SNAP HQ and got the retired Tk window, labelled with the new version number 0.7.67. “WHY is a reverted, pre-Qt version of SYBU launching now????”
Theme	The exe-builder’s recipe files were kept out of git, so each working copy of the repository carried its own frozen recipe. One stale recipe still pointed at the old window. A build from that folder installed the old program under the new number, and the version check, the icon check and the “built successfully” line all passed.
Surfaces	The SYBU desktop tool; the PyInstaller build recipes for every desktop tool (<code>tools/<tool>/<tool>.spec</code>); <code>.gitignore</code> ; the shared build discipline for GYSS, COLD SNAP, FED UP, SNAP HQ and the rest.
State	WATCHED WORKING SYBU 0.7.68 rebuilt from the Qt recipe 2026-09-15 21:59 and again 22:26; entry script read out of the installed exe (<code>sybu_launcher</code>); Sean launched it from SNAP HQ and posted 8 images through it.
Watched live?	Yes. The defect: the installed exe’s archive was read and its entry script was <code>main</code> (Tk), built by Python 3.10, not the suite’s 3.12. The fix: the same read after the rebuild says <code>sybu_launcher</code> , Python 3.12, icon present; then a real posting run.
Reporter	Sean (saw the wrong window and said so) + Claude (built the wrong exe that morning; found the stale recipe; fixed the discipline).
Related	OPAUDIT 016 (the desktop tool that looked right and was wrong); the GYSS version-floor regression still open on <code>dev</code> (same class: a build input drifting behind the code).
Publication	Public. No exploitable detail. One user (Sean) runs every affected machine.

1. SUMMARY

SMACK YOUR BATCH UP moved from its old Tk window to a Qt window on 2026-09-12. The Qt window reads the version number from the same file the old window does, so both windows say “0.7.67”. Which window the exe opens is decided by one line in the build recipe — the PyInstaller `.spec` file — and that file was on the repository’s ignore list since May (`tools/*/*.spec` , added to stop a clutter of per-version clones). Ignored files do not travel with commits. Every working copy of the repository kept whatever recipe it had when it was created. The working copy used for the 07:38 build on 2026-09-15 was created on 2026-09-10, two days before the Qt switch; its recipe still said `Analysis(['main.py'])` . The build ran, on whatever `pyinstaller` was on the system path (Python 3.10, not the suite’s 3.12), printed “built

successfully”, installed a 153 MB Tk exe as `C:\snapsmack\sybu\sybu.exe`, and SNAP HQ launched it. The version was right. The icon was right. The program was wrong.

2. WHAT A HUMAN SAW

When	What
2026-09-15, 07:38	SYBU 0.7.67 “built” from a worktree, committed, memory updated: “SYBU 0.7.67 built”.
2026-09-15, ~19:30	Sean launches SYBU from SNAP HQ. Green LED-style status bar, six tabs (SMACKONEOUT / GRAMOFSMACK / AUDIT / BASIC REPAIR / ADV. MATCH / SETTINGS), title “build 0.7.67”. That is the Tk window retired three days earlier.
Diagnosis, ~5 min	Every shortcut and SNAP HQ’s launcher point at the one exe. Read the exe’s PyInstaller archive directly: entry scripts end in <code>main</code> ; Python 3.10. The main checkout’s <code>sybu.spec</code> says <code>sybu_launcher.py</code> ; the worktree’s says <code>main.py</code> ; the worktree’s <code>build-sybu.log</code> confirms “Analyzing ... \tools\sybu\main.py” under Python 3.10.6.
21:59	Rebuilt from the main checkout with the suite interpreter. Archive read: <code>sybu_launcher</code> , Python 3.12, icon present. Installed, trusted.
21:5x–22:26	Sean uses the Qt build; three parity gaps surface in an hour (no drag/randomize, two POST buttons, no posting feedback — 8 images posted silently, confirmed on the site’s RSS). Fixed and rebuilt at 22:26. Those gaps are a separate ledger item (SYBU Qt parity), not this one.

3. ROOT CAUSE — THREE LAYERS

A build input outside version control. The recipe that decides what the exe *is* was treated as a generated artefact and ignored. It is code. Anything the build needs to produce the program has to travel with the program’s source, or the two drift. Sean’s rule, stated that night: “if it is necessary for building it goes on git. If it is private notes it does not.”

Building from a working copy that was not the main checkout. Worktrees are cut from a moment in time; ignored files in them are frozen at that moment. A build from a worktree therefore builds against stale inputs it cannot see are stale.

Verification that checked the wrong things. The post-build checks were version string, icon resource, “build successful”. None of those can tell a Tk exe from a Qt exe when both carry the same version file. The one check that can — which script the exe actually runs — was not made.

4. EVIDENCE AT DIAGNOSIS

Where	What it said
<code>C:\snapsmack\sybu\sybu.exe</code> (07:38 build), PyInstaller archive TOC	Python 310; entry scripts ... <code>pyi_rth__tkinter</code> , <code>main</code>

<code>tools/sybu/sybu.spec</code> in the main checkout (2026-09-12)	<code>Analysis(['sybu_launcher.py'], ...)</code>
Same file in worktree <code>opaudits-install-mode-4</code> (2026-09-10)	<code>Analysis(['main.py'], ...)</code> with tkinter hidden imports
That worktree's <code>build-sybu.log</code>	“Python: 3.10.6 ... C:\Users\neutr\AppData\Local\Programs\Python\Python310 ... Analyzing ...\tools\sybu\main.py”
<code>.gitignore</code> line 122, since 0.7.159 (2026-05-20)	<code>tools/*/*.spec</code>
Untracked live recipes found by the sweep	<code>sybu.spec</code> , <code>fed-up.spec</code> , <code>blogger-flogger.spec</code> ; plus two dead Tk recipes (<code>coldsnap.spec</code> , <code>flkrfckr.spec</code>) waiting to do the same thing, and 22 stale per-version clones.
<code>tools/sybu/sybu_qt.py</code>	Carried its own <code>BUILD_VERSION = "0.7.66"</code> while <code>main.py</code> said 0.7.67 — a second copy of the version, already drifted.

5. WHAT WE DID (SYBU 0.7.68, DEV COMMITS 8E6E4FA1 → 65F61CB4)

- Rebuilt SYBU from the main checkout with `.python-build`; verified the entry script, interpreter and icon by reading the installed exe; trusted it; Sean ran it.
- `build.bat` refuses to build if the recipe does not launch `sybu_launcher.py`, and always calls the suite's own `pyinstaller.exe`, never the one on the path.
- The Qt window reads its version from `main.py` instead of carrying a copy.
- The ignore rule is gone. Every live recipe is tracked (`sybu`, `fed-up`, `blogger-flogger` added; the other ten already were). The two dead Tk recipes and the 22 version clones are deleted. Only `tools/*/*-N.N.spec` clones stay ignored.
- Version floor raised to 0.7.68 in `tools/desktop-versions.json` in the same commit.

6. VERIFIED

Installed exe archive after each rebuild: last entry script `sybu_launcher`, Python 312, `RT_GROUP_ICON` present. `git ls-files` lists every `*.spec` under `tools/`; a sweep for untracked live recipes returns none. Sean launched 0.7.68 from SNAP HQ and posted 8 images to craptasti.ca through it (03:39 UTC on the site's RSS).

7. EYEBALL NEXT

The GYSS floor regression on dev (`tauri.conf.json` 0.7.10 against a floor of 0.7.17) — same family, not yet explained. And the next rebuild of any tool: read the entry script out of the exe before saying “built”.

8. THE DOCTRINE THIS INCIDENT CREATED

Anything the build needs is code and lives in git. A build is verified by reading what the installed program is — its entry point — not by its version string, its icon, or the word “successful”. And a desktop tool is built from one place, the main checkout, with one interpreter, the suite’s own.

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